

The Little Vagabond



POEM TEXT

- 1 Dear Mother, dear Mother, the Church is cold,
- 2 But the Ale-house is healthy & pleasant & warm;
- 3 Besides I can tell where I am use'd well,
- 4 Such usage in heaven will never do well.
- 5 But if at the Church they would give us some Ale.
- 6 And a pleasant fire, our souls to regale;
- 7 We'd sing and we'd pray, all the live-long day;
- 8 Nor ever once wish from the Church to stray,
- 9 Then the Parson might preach & drink & sing.
- 10 And we'd be as happy as birds in the spring;
- 11 And modest dame Lurch, who is always at Church,
- 12 Would not have bandy children nor fasting nor birch.
- 13 And God like a father rejoicing to see,
- 14 His children as pleasant and happy as he:
- 15 Would have no more quarrel with the Devil or the Barrel
- 16 But kiss him & give him both drink and apparel.



THEMES



THE FAILINGS OF ORGANIZED RELIGION

In "The Little Vagabond," a child wonders why on earth the church shouldn't be more like an "Ale-house" (a pub, that is): a warm, comforting, cheerful place that makes everyone welcome. Such a service, he reflects, would be far more pleasurable to attend, and no one would ever think of "stray[ing]" from this "happy" environment. By adopting the inviting atmosphere of a pub, the church would serve more people, and serve them *better*. Through this irreverent-sounding idea, the poem critiques the cold rigidity of organized Christianity (and especially the Church of England, the dominant religion in Blake's England). As things stand, the poem hints, organized religion does more harm than good, oppressing and driving away those it should welcome in—and working *against* people's natural religious feelings.

The young speaker sees the church as cheerless and punitive. The building itself is "cold" and unpleasant to be in, but the institution is also [symbolically](#) cold. Rather than inviting its people in, it encourages them to treat themselves as miserable sinners, punishing themselves with "fasting" (or restricted eating) and their children with "birch[ings]" (or whippings). In short, it's an institution that seems like the opposite of the "heaven" it preaches about: loveless, stern, and uninviting.

No wonder, then, that the speaker innocently asks his mother why the church isn't more like an "Ale-house." "I can tell where I am used well," the speaker says, and it's not the church: the pub is the much more humane gathering place! If the church were as warm, welcoming, and cheery as the pub, he says, it would become a much more desirable place to be, and no one would ever have cause to leave. Rather, they'd "sing and [...] pray all the live-long day," reveling in an inherent religiosity—an attitude that the poem suggests comes naturally when people are well cared for.

The speaker's apparently childish, irreverent idea that the church should be more like a pub thus becomes a critique of organized Christianity. The church, the speaker suggests, uses a stick where it should use a carrot: people *want* to "sing and [...] pray," but kindness and warmth motivate such natural piety much more than hidebound religion and cold rules can. The "Little Vagabond" who dares suggest that the church should be more like an ale-house isn't a young ruffian, then, but a kid with a good point.

Where this theme appears in the poem:



SUMMARY

Mother dear, the church is chilly, but the local pub is full of life, pleasure, and warmth. I can tell where I'm treated well, and the way the church treats us would never be accepted in Heaven.

If the church would only offer our souls some ale and a crackling fire, we'd spend the whole day singing and praying, and we'd never dream of leaving.

The parson could still preach while drinking and having fun. And the congregation would be happy as birds when spring comes. Meanwhile, prim Mrs. Lurch, who's always at church, wouldn't have sad skinny-legged children, and wouldn't starve them or beat them.

And God would be like a father beaming down on children who are as happy as he is. He would have no more reason to argue with the Devil or forbid ale; instead, he'd kiss the Devil and offer him a drink and some clothes.

- Lines 1-16



RECONCILING GOOD AND EVIL

"The Little Vagabond" subtly suggests that the church's problem isn't just that it's "cold" and inflexible, but that it has a rigid, binary idea of morality. Through the speaker's vision of God and "the Devil" reconciling over a glass of ale, the poem implies that letting go of rigid beliefs about morality (and especially about the idea that pleasure and comfort are sinful) will allow people to lead happier, richer lives.

The poem's speaker—an innocent child—sees nothing strange in the idea that God and the Devil might eventually settle their differences. To him, then, good and evil aren't fixed, opposite points; the problem with the Devil isn't that he's inherently evil, but that he and God are currently opposed to each other rather than living in harmony.

This creation of a rigid moral binary, the poem suggests, is exactly the problem with organized Christianity. By cutting itself off from things it perceives as worldly, sinful, unholy—like bodily pleasure and plain old enjoyment—it only creates the evils it supposedly strives to resist.

The little speaker's idea that church should be more like a pub offers a solution to this problem. If one ceases to think of the church as the height of morality and the ale-house as the epitome of depravity, but rather views them both as aspects of human experience, there's suddenly no need to separate them. The child's vision takes the sin out of the ale-house by incorporating its warmth and festivity into the church rather than pitting its pleasures against it. This leaves everyone freer to enjoy embodied life, while also excluding no one from prayer and worship.

The speaker concludes that once God sees how happy his "children" are in this new and improved church, he'll have "no more quarrel with the Devil"—suggesting that God and the Devil will no longer be opposite forces. Indeed, the child's instinct to merge the church and the ale-house into one harmonious whole might also be seen as a way of reconciling religion with the things the church presents as evil—physical pleasure most especially! It turns out, Blake suggests, that people don't have to choose between their desire for religious experience and for physical enjoyment. In fact, only by uniting the two can they lead rounded and fulfilling lives.

Where this theme appears in the poem:

- Lines 13-16



LINE-BY-LINE ANALYSIS

LINES 1-4

*Dear Mother, dear Mother, the Church is cold,
But the Ale-house is healthy & pleasant & warm;
Besides I can tell where I am use'd well,
Such usage in heaven will never do well.*

"The Little Vagabond" is spoken in the voice of that little vagabond himself—that is, a little rover or rogue. As the poem begins, readers might picture him squirming on a hard church pew, tugging on his mother's sleeve:

Dear Mother, dear Mother, the Church is cold,

His insistent [epizeuxis](#) on the words "dear Mother" establishes his imploring [tone](#): he's terribly uncomfortable and wants to leave this chilly place for greener pastures. Just for example, he suggests, he and his mother might head for the "Ale-house"—the local pub, which looks awfully "healthy & pleasant & warm" in [juxtaposition](#) with the cold church. He clearly feels more welcome in the pub, where he says he is "use'd well," treated kindly. The way the church treats him, by contrast, would never go over "in heaven."

Such an assessment of the relative goodness of church and pub—especially in the voice of a child—would have sounded pretty scandalous in Blake's time. But this poem will suggest that the little vagabond has a good point. His innocent, common-sense observation that the pub is kindly and the church is cruel sets the stage for a critique of organized religion more generally. If this kid is a vagabond, the cold, rigid, hidebound church has made him one, driving him away when it could welcome him home.

The poem is made up of four [quatrains](#) (four-line stanzas); each is divided into two [couplets](#) by its AABB [rhyme scheme](#). While most of the poem adheres strictly to this pattern, the first two lines (comparing the church and the pub) don't rhyme, a choice that emphasizes the difference between the "cold" church and the "warm" alehouse.

The poem is written in accentual meter. That means its lines all use a certain number of beats (four, in this case) without sticking to any one metrical foot (like the [iamb](#) or the [trochee](#)). This flexible rhythm sounds naturalistic and conversational, believably capturing the voice of a little kid. Its changeability also helps to create a mood—for instance, by emphasizing the very different atmospheres of the Church and Ale-house, as it does in lines 1-2:

Dear Mother, dear Mother, the Church is cold,
But the Ale-house is healthy & pleasant & warm;

The stumbling, awkward rhythms of the first line make the

church sound plain *uncomfortable*. The second line, meanwhile, trots by in steady [anapests](#) (metrical feet with a da-da-DUM rhythm, as in "But the Ale") suggesting how much more easy, free, and happy the speaker feels when he's at the pub.

LINES 5-8

*But if at the Church they would give us some Ale.
And a pleasant fire, our souls to regale;
We'd sing and we'd pray, all the live-long day;
Nor ever once wish from the Church to stray,*

In the second stanza, the child proposes a solution to the church/pub problem. If the church would only provide "Ale / And a pleasant fire" to warm and delight people's "souls," he points out, then there'd be no need to go to the alehouse at all.

In other words, the child doesn't dislike the church because he's wicked or doesn't want to commune with God, but because church is a cold, unwelcoming place to be. If he could have *both* religious experience *and* physical comforts, then he wouldn't be dreaming of other places while he's at church.

Indeed, he says that if these creaturely needs were met, *everyone* would be naturally, cheerfully pious. Listen to the jolly [parallelism](#) in these lines:

*We'd sing and we'd pray, all the live-long day;
Nor ever once wish from the Church to stray.*

That repetition, with its emphasis on the word "we'd," stresses the little vagabond's point that *everyone* would be made happier if the church were more like the pub. No one would turn away from religion if the church were a fun, pleasant, and welcoming place to be.

If this idea sounds irreverent—well, that just makes Blake's point! These lines ask the question: *why should* religion be split apart from creature comforts? *Why shouldn't* the church be as concerned with the wellbeing of its congregation's bodies as the good of their souls? And, perhaps most pointedly of all: *why should* the church behave as if people need to be bullied into believing, when a joyous, musical faith apparently comes naturally to this little vagabond?

LINES 9-12

*Then the Parson might preach & drink & sing.
And we'd be as happy as birds in the spring:
And modest dame Lurch, who is always at Church,
Would not have bandy children nor fasting nor birch.*

The little vagabond continues his dream of what the church might learn from the alehouse. In his vision, even the "Parson" himself "might preach & drink & sing" right along with his congregation. Again, this might come across as an ever so slightly irreverent suggestion, calling up images of a sermon delivered through hiccups (an impression that the bouncy

[polysyndeton](#) of "preach & drink & sing" helps to create). But the speaker doesn't see the idea of the parson having a good time as any more sinful than the idea of everyone else having a good time.

If the parson and all his congregation were allowed to have a little fun at church, the speaker declares, "we'd be as happy as birds in the spring." This [simile](#) suggests that adding a little liveliness and cheer to the church would wake everyone up, just as spring rouses birds from their winter quiet. Suddenly people would *want* to praise God (much as the birds sing at the coming of warmer weather and blossoms) instead of just feeling obligated to.

For that matter, a warm and convivial church would make a better woman of "modest dame Lurch, who is always at Church." There's more than a little [irony](#) in the speaker's description of this lady as "modest" (or sober and respectable): she's certainly a pious churchgoer, but that hasn't made her a good or a kind person. She's mother to a crowd of "bandy" (or scrawny and bowlegged) children whom she keeps in line with "fasting" (restricted food) and the "birch" (whippings with a birch stick).

The [internal rhyme](#) between "Lurch" and "Church" highlights the relationship between this frightful figure and the church itself, making Dame Lurch a [symbol](#) of the repressive, punitive "mother church" that should be nourishing and caring for its children, its congregation.

LINES 13-16

*And God like a father rejoicing to see,
His children as pleasant and happy as he:
Would have no more quarrel with the Devil or the Barrel
But kiss him & give him both drink and apparel.*

If the church were reformed along alehouse lines, the little vagabond concludes, everyone would be happier—even God himself, who would, "like a father," only "rejoic[e] to see, / His children as pleasant and happy as he."

This [simile](#) draws on the Christian tradition that God is a loving father figure. If that's so, the speaker suggests, then surely he would want his "children" to enjoy themselves. There is no reason why they can't praise him while also having a good time!

At the same time, the speaker suggests that God himself is by nature a lot more pleasant than the church would suggest: he wants his children to be "as pleasant and happy as he." Rather than punishing and austere, this God is jolly, loving, and inclusive. This flies in the face of the idea—inexcusably prominent in organized Christianity, Blake felt—that God needs to be an imposing figure in order to scare people into following inflexible rules.

In fact, the child argues that making the Church a more welcoming place would dismantle the need for tired moral binaries altogether. If God's children were happy, then God

"would have no more quarrel with the Devil or the Barrel." In other words:

- If the church were pleasant, God's children wouldn't abandon it for the alehouse, and thus the supposedly sinful and devilish pleasures inside would no longer be God's enemy.
- Instead, God would "kiss [the Devil] & give him both drink and apparel" (or clothes), suggesting that good and evil would be reconciled, and human beings would feel whole.
- That God would clothe the Devil furthermore suggests that no one would be standing outside the Church suffering because they were deemed unworthy of divine love and guidance. *Everyone* would be brought into the fold, and the world would be an all-round better place.

This poem's cheeky humor thus smuggles in some grand philosophical ideas. The pleasures of the body, Blake suggests, aren't the enemies of the spirit; in fact, physical delight and spiritual delight are two sides of the same coin. When organized religion tries to split the two, it only *creates* the idea of evil—and creates little vagabonds, for that matter, wandering souls who know better than to hang out in places where they aren't "use'd well." That this sweet young speaker's good sense could be read as shocking or irreverent is itself a critique of a hidebound, punitive, binary church.

which church is a place where people go for warmth and fellowship, rather than a place that punishes people to keep them in line. The pious but cruel Dame Lurch thus becomes an image of the church itself: a mean mother beating the kids she should care for.

Indeed, the poem suggests that the whole reason people turn away from organized religion in the first place is because of its rigidity and cruelty. If people were instead welcomed into the church and treated well, the speaker suggests, there would be no need for such punishment, since it is human nature to want to connect with the divine.

Where this symbol appears in the poem:

- **Lines 11-12:** "And modest dame Lurch, who is always at Church, / Would not have bandy children nor fasting nor birch."



POETIC DEVICES

REPETITION

"The Little Vagabond" uses [repetition](#) to capture the little speaker's chirpy voice (and his comical conviction).

Take, for example, the [epizeuxis](#) in line 1:

Dear Mother, dear Mother, the Church is cold,

These two "Dear Mother"s come in quick succession, like tugs on a sleeve, and establish the child's urgent, pleading [tone](#). He is supremely uncomfortable in the church, and really needs his mother to hear his bright idea for solving this problem: make the church more like a pub!

He gives some of his reasons for this plan in lines 3-4, using some emphatic [polyptoton](#) and [epistrophe](#):

Besides I can tell where I am use'd well,
Such usage in heaven will never do well.

The polyptoton on "use'd" and "usage" sets up a clear contrast between the way the pub and the church "use" (or treat) the boy. Similarly, his epistrophe on "well" (which also creates a bold identical rhyme) stresses that the church isn't treating anyone "well" at all. Rather, it's cruel and repressive in a way that the speaker can't imagine would go over "well" in heaven.

In line 7, he pictures the much more cheerful scene of a church that had learned some lessons from the pub. Here, the [parallelism](#) of "We'd sing and we'd pray" emphasizes the word "we," suggesting that a more welcoming, pleasure-oriented church would invite everyone in—and make everyone *want* to sing and pray, as if it came naturally to them.



SYMBOLS



WARMTH AND COLD

Shivering in church, this poem's speaker longs for the ale-house and the warmth of its "pleasant fire." It's clear that the child's desire for warmth isn't just about being physically comfortable, but about the emotional comfort that warmth [symbolizes](#). In other words, he's longing for a humane, loving version of religion in which people "sing" and "pray" because they *want* to, not because they're afraid of being punished by a literally and figuratively "cold," unfeeling church.

Where this symbol appears in the poem:

- **Lines 1-2:** "the Church is cold, / But the Ale-house is healthy & pleasant & warm;"
- **Line 6:** "a pleasant fire"



DAME LURCH

Dame Lurch and her "birch" (that is, the stick she uses to beat her children) [symbolize](#) the church and its punitive attitudes. The poem's speaker imagines a world in

In such a church, he goes on, with cheery [anaphora](#) and [polysyndeton](#):

[...] the Parson might preach & drink & sing.
And we'd be as happy as birds in the spring:
And modest dame Lurch, who is always as Church,
Would not have bandy children nor fasting nor birch.
And God like a father rejoicing to see,

The momentum of that string of "and"s shows the speaker caught up in his imagination, carried away from the dreariness of his present circumstance toward a more joyful version of church.

Where Repetition appears in the poem:

- **Line 1:** "Dear Mother, dear Mother,"
- **Line 3:** "use'd well"
- **Line 4:** "usage," "well"
- **Line 7:** "We'd," "we'd"
- **Line 10:** "And"
- **Line 11:** "And"
- **Line 13:** "And"

POLYSYNDETON

Alongside other forms of [repetition](#), the poem uses [polysyndeton](#) to create a speedy, rollicking rhythm that suits the child speaker.

For instance, polysyndeton in line 2 evokes the speaker's enthusiasm:

But the Ale-house is healthy & pleasant & warm;

"The Ale-house is healthy, pleasant, and warm" would be perfectly grammatical, but it would also feel more reserved and sedate. The extra conjunction here captures the speaker's childish excitement as he describes a place where he always feels "warm" and welcome.

Something similar happens in line 9:

Then the Parson might preach & drink & sing.

Again, that extra "&" makes it sound as if the speaker is getting carried away with glee as he imagines how much more enjoyable church could be. The jaunty swing of the polysyndeton here also feels fitting for a vision of a tipsy parson joyously preaching (perhaps through hiccups).

In lines 11-12, meanwhile, the speaker relishes the thought that, in his pub-church:

[...] modest dame Lurch, who is always at Church,
Would not have bandy children **nor** fasting **nor** birch.

That double "nor" is just as cheery as the multiple "and"s above. But it also captures the speaker's delight at getting rid of bad things about church, not just adding good things to it: *Away with getting whipped and going to bed without your supper!*

Where Polysyndeton appears in the poem:

- **Line 2:** "&," "&"
- **Line 9:** "&," "&"
- **Line 12:** "nor," "nor"

JUXTAPOSITION

Throughout, the poem [juxtaposes](#) the "cold" church with the "healthy & pleasant & warm" alehouse, suggesting that organized religion foolishly and needlessly splits itself off from the joy of being alive.

To most readers, the idea that the church should be more like a pub will come across as plainly irreverent, at least at first. This poem's speaker, however, is innocent enough to ask: why should that be? His vision of a pub-like church is even rather pious. If the church were as warm and welcoming as the alehouse, he suggests, it would be the better of the two options, offering not just a toasty fire and tasty ale but the innate pleasure of prayer and song.

But to the church, the alehouse is an opposite and an enemy. Just as "God" is opposed to "the Devil," the church and the pub can never meet. Church is for piety, the pub is for sinful pleasure.

It's just such rigid, binary "cold[ness]," the poem suggests, that causes people to "stray" from the church in the first place. If people have to choose between religious experience and feeling good, chances are pretty good they're going to choose the latter—or at least "wish" to. After all, the speaker may be physically sitting in church, but because he's so uncomfortable, his mind is at the pub. He's torn between one way of being and the other.

However, if people were to integrate these equally important aspects of being human—spirit and body—then no one would be forced to choose between them, and everyone could outright *enjoy* their natural piety. Even God, the speaker suggests, would "have no more quarrel with the Devil"—a striking image of reconciling apparent opposites!

Where Juxtaposition appears in the poem:

- **Lines 1-2:** "the Church is cold, / But the Ale-house is healthy & pleasant & warm"
- **Lines 13-16:** "And God like a father rejoicing to see, / His children as pleasant and happy as he: / Would have no more quarrel with the Devil or the Barrel / But kiss him & give him both drink and apparel."

SIMILE

The poem uses [similes](#) to help illustrate how much better the speaker feels church would be if it were a bit more like a pub.

In line 10, the speaker says that if the church included "drink[ing]" and "sing[ing]" in addition to "preach[ing]," then the congregation would "be as happy as birds in the spring." This simile suggests the thawing of the emotional "cold[ness]" of the church: birds greet spring happily because it means the end of a harsh winter. Spring also often [symbolizes](#) youth, vitality, and new beginnings, hinting the church would be revitalized by softening its rigid rules and becoming a more welcoming place.

In lines 13-14, meanwhile, the speaker compares God to "a father rejoicing to see, / His children as pleasant and happy as he." By presenting God as a father who is thrilled to see his children happy, the poem challenges the need for a strict, uncompromising, and miserable church—and a strict, uncompromising, miserable vision of God! If God is indeed a loving father (as God is so often described in Christianity), the speaker says, then what he really wants is to see his children enjoying themselves.

Where Simile appears in the poem:

- **Line 10:** "And we'd be as happy as birds in the spring:"
- **Lines 13-14:** "And God like a father rejoicing to see, / His children as pleasant and happy as he:"



VOCABULARY

Vagabond () - A wanderer; someone who has no home. The word has some connotations of roguishness or mischief—a "vagabond" might be the kind of person who'd steal a pie off your windowsill. By giving the speaker this name, Blake both suggests that the organized Christian church offers this boy no real home and makes a little joke about the boy's idea that church should be more like a pub. The speaker's suggestion is totally innocent, but it might *sound* rather roguish to, say, a tight-lipped and pious "dame Lurch"!

Ale-house (Line 2) - A pub.

Use'd well (Line 3) - Treated well, respected.

Usage (Line 4) - Treatment.

Regale (Line 6) - "Regale" can mean "entertain" or "abundantly supply"—and both meanings are relevant here!

Live-long (Line 7) - All day long.

Parson (Line 9) - Preacher, clergyman.

Modest dame Lurch (Line 11) - A humble woman by the name of "Lurch." This unappealing name is also a word meaning "to move suddenly," perhaps suggesting that Dame Lurch is always running around after her unfortunate children.

Bandy (Line 12) - Stunted and bow-legged. Dame Lurch, this image suggests, doesn't feed her children very well.

Fasting (Line 12) - Intentionally restricting one's diet—in this case, for religious reasons.

Birch (Line 12) - A birch stick used for whipping children. A "birching" was a beating.

Quarrel (Line 15) - Argument, disagreement.

Barrel (Line 15) - A [metonym](#) for alcohol generally: ale was stored in barrels.

Apparel (Line 16) - Clothing.



FORM, METER, & RHYME

FORM

"The Little Vagabond" is made up of four [quatrains](#) (four-line stanzas) written in accentual meter (lines measured, not in regular feet like the [iamb](#) or the [trochee](#), but by a certain number of beats—four, in this case). Each stanza can be further broken down into two [couplets](#) based on the poem's AABB [rhyme scheme](#).

This simple, nursery-rhyme-ish shape is a good fit for a poem spoken by a sweet little boy. By presenting the boy's apparently irreverent ideas in this jaunty, playful form, Blake emphasizes this little vagabond's basic innocence. This child doesn't prefer the pub to the church because he's sinful, but because he's *human*—a quality the church could stand to learn from!

In its simplicity, this poem also fits right in with many of its fellows in the *Songs of Innocence and of Experience*. Throughout that collection, Blake uses plain forms to communicate complex ideas, wild philosophies, and [deep outrage](#).

METER

The poem is written in accentual meter. That means that the lines use a regular number of beats—four, in this case—without sticking to any one kind of metrical foot (like the [iamb](#) or the [dactyl](#)). Listen, for instance, to the changing rhythms of the first two lines:

Dear Mother, dear Mother, the Church is cold,
But the Ale-house is healthy & pleasant & warm;

The clunky rhythm of line 1 stresses the speaker's discomfort: the line lands hard on the word "cold." In contrast, the second line uses all [anapests](#) (metrical feet with a da-da-DUM rhythm, as in "But the Ale"), giving a jauntier, easier rhythm to the boy's visions of the cozy ale-house.

Throughout the poem, changing rhythms thus capture the speaker's mood and his cheeky energy, making his voice sound lively and naturalistic.

RHYME SCHEME

For the most part, the poem follows an AABB [rhyme scheme](#) that divides each stanza into two [couplets](#). This perky, singsongy pattern evokes the innocent, childish voice of the "Little Vagabond," and thus helps to make the poem's mischievous point: even a little kid can see that the church lacks the attractions the ale-house offers. A bouncy [internal rhyme](#) in line 11 ("And modest dame Lurch, who is always at Church") similarly captures the child's alert, funny voice.

The only place the poem diverges from this pattern is in lines 1-2:

Dear Mother, dear Mother, the Church is cold,
But the Ale-house is healthy & pleasant & warm;

The absence of a rhyme at the beginning of an otherwise strictly rhymed poem reflects exactly what these lines describe: the way that organized religion has split off and rejected the "warm[th]" of ordinary human comforts.



SPEAKER

The speaker of "The Little Vagabond" is a child speaking to his mother—perhaps from the very "Church" he complains about. Uncomfortable and bored on a chilly pew, he longs for the warmth and vibrancy of the "Ale-house," and very reasonably suggests that church would be a whole lot nicer if it were as toasty and full of good things to eat as the pub is.

The poem's title and the child's familiarity with the ale-house both suggest he isn't exactly at home in the church. But it's the church itself, the poem hints, that has made him a "vagabond": the rigidity of organized religion is exactly what makes people "stray." This little boy wouldn't be yearning for the pub if the church weren't so dreary and punitive.

The idea of a child seeing more joy and goodness in the pub than the church is meant to be a little scandalous—something that a pious "dame Lurch" wouldn't approve of one bit. But the child's vision also offers a serious critique of organized Christianity and its binary idea of morality.



SETTING

The poem is set in a physically and emotionally cold "Church," where a child sits dreaming of being at "the Ale-house" instead. Besides its coldness, the church offers this child only dreary boredom and menace: it's frequented by figures like "modest dame Lurch," a pious monster of a woman who uses "fasting" (restricted eating) and the "birch" (whippings) to keep her unfortunate children toeing the line.

The child's critique of this chilly church becomes a critique of

the Church in general: that is, of organized Christianity, which the poem suggests is generally punitive and repressive. The speaker offers a solution, too. If the church could be more like an "Ale-house," he says—that is, a warm, convivial place where everyone was well-fed—then everyone would be happy while they worshiped, and singing and praying would come naturally.

The poem's contrasting settings suggest that a big part of the problem with organized religion is its neglect (and rejection) of bodily pleasure. In treating the needs of the body as sins, the poem's innocently wise "Little Vagabond" suggests, the church only cuts itself off from life and joy.



CONTEXT

LITERARY CONTEXT

William Blake (1757-1827) is revered as one of the most influential figures in the history of English literature. Though he is now often considered one of the earliest of the [Romantic](#) poets because of his ideals regarding nature, the imagination, and creativity, he was seen as peculiar and even deranged in his own time. Unlike contemporaries such as [Samuel Taylor Coleridge](#) and [William Wordsworth](#), he struggled to find an audience—either popular or critical—that understood or appreciated his work.

Part of this is due to the visionary quality of Blake's poetry. Blake spoke of witnessing angels and other spiritual phenomena since his early childhood, and these experiences informed his work to such a degree that even Coleridge, himself a [visionary](#), [remarked](#) that he was quite "common-place" compared to Blake.

Blake published "The Little Vagabond" in his 1794 book *Songs of Innocence and of Experience*, in which he expanded on his 1789 collection *Songs of Innocence*. As a whole, this two-part collection explores what Blake called "the two contrary states of the human soul," and can be seen as a re-envisioning of the biblical tale of the Garden of Eden and humanity's fall from grace.

Blake's writing was meant to instill moral lessons, but not simple ones: the deceptively plainspoken poems in this collection can be interpreted in many ways. Blake even moved poems back and forth between the *Innocence* and *Experience* sections of the book, proving that these poems aren't always straightforward depictions of one side of human experience or the other. Many of the poems in *Innocence* correspond directly to a poem in *Experience*; while "The Little Vagabond" has no direct counterpart, it's one of a number of poems in the collection that criticize organized religion, from "[The Garden of Love](#)" to the two takes on "Holy Thursday" in [Innocence](#) and [Experience](#).

HISTORICAL CONTEXT

William Blake was a deeply religious man, but he was highly critical of *organized* religion. He was born to a family of Dissenters, a group of English Protestants who broke away from and rebelled against the Church of England (and instilled in Blake an early distrust of the religious status quo). He generally saw top-down religious structures as getting in the way of a direct relationship between humanity and God.

For that matter, he believed—and memorably said, in his *Marriage of Heaven and Hell*—that "everything that lives is holy." To Blake, the whole world was infused with divinity, which people could see if only they opened their eyes to the "infinite that was hid" behind the illusions of custom and daily life.

In this, he (like many of his Romantic contemporaries) rebelled against the rationalistic worldviews of 18th-century Enlightenment philosophers. He was also influenced by the revolutions (French and American) taking place in the world around him. Seeing that societal and religious constructs could be broken down and new liberties gained, Blake used his work to address social issues like the [mistreatment of children](#) and [racism](#).

the Church of England in particular), and how he created his own literary mythology to counter it.

<https://www.thecollector.com/william-blake-mythology-4-states-of-mind/>

LITCHARTS ON OTHER WILLIAM BLAKE POEMS

- [A Dream](#)
- [Ah! Sun-flower](#)
- [A Poison Tree](#)
- [Earth's Answer](#)
- [Holy Thursday \(Songs of Experience\)](#)
- [Holy Thursday \(Songs of Innocence\)](#)
- [Infant Joy](#)
- [Infant Sorrow](#)
- [Introduction \(Songs of Innocence\)](#)
- [London](#)
- [Nurse's Song \(Songs of Experience\)](#)
- [Nurse's Song \(Songs of Innocence\)](#)
- [The Chimney Sweeper \(Songs of Experience\)](#)
- [The Chimney Sweeper \(Songs of Innocence\)](#)
- [The Clod and the Pebble](#)
- [The Divine Image](#)
- [The Ecchoing Green](#)
- [The Fly](#)
- [The Garden of Love](#)
- [The Lamb](#)
- [The Little Black Boy](#)
- [The School Boy](#)
- [The Sick Rose](#)
- [The Tyger](#)
- [To Autumn](#)
- [To the Evening Star](#)



MORE RESOURCES

EXTERNAL RESOURCES

- [The Poem Illuminated](#) — See an image of the poem as Blake originally imagined and published it: as a beautifully illuminated manuscript. (<https://www.blakearchive.org/copy/songsie.b?descId=songsie.b.illbk.37>)
- [Blake's Infernal Method](#) — Watch a video discussing Blake's innovative printing technique and what it meant to him. (<https://www.openculture.com/2022/05/william-blake-the-remarkable-printing-process-of-the-english-poet-artist-visionary.html>)
- [A Brief Biography](#) — Learn about Blake's life and work in this article from the Poetry Foundation. (<https://www.poetryfoundation.org/poets/william-blake>)
- [An Overview of British Romanticism](#) — Read the British Library's introduction to the literary movement Blake helped set in motion. (<https://www.bl.uk/romantics-and-victorians/articles/the-romantics>)
- [William Blake and Organized Religion](#) — Read an article examining Blake's relationship to organized religion (and



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